

Moving Company Pricing Guide 2026: What to Charge for Local and Long-Distance Moves

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Pricing is where most moving companies silently lose money — either by charging too little and destroying margins, or by charging too much and losing jobs to competitors who aren't.

This guide gives you real 2026 pricing data, a framework for setting your rates, and the fee structures that protect your margins on every job type.

Why Moving Pricing Is More Complex Than Most Service Businesses

Unlike dumpster rental or lawn care, moving pricing has multiple legitimate structures:

Hourly: You charge by the hour with a minimum. Works well for local moves where total time is unpredictable. Customers like the transparency; you're protected if the job takes longer than expected.

Flat-rate: You give a fixed quote for the whole job. Works well for long-distance and larger moves where customers want certainty. Your risk if the job takes longer than estimated.

Hybrid: Hourly rate with a flat-rate cap. "We charge \$145/hour with a 4-hour minimum — once we hit \$900, it's capped there." Offers customer certainty while protecting you from jobs that run short.

Which structure you use affects your pricing in different ways. Understand this before setting any rates.

2026 Local Moving Rates by Market Size

Local moves are typically priced hourly. Rates vary significantly by market.

2-Person Crew + Truck (Most Common for Residential)

Market Type	Rate Per Hour	3-Hour Minimum	Common 4-Hour Job Total
Major metro (NYC, LA, Chicago, Miami)	\$130 – \$200/hr	\$390 – \$600	\$520 – \$800
Mid-size city (Denver, Atlanta, Phoenix)	\$100 – \$150/hr	\$300 – \$450	\$400 – \$600
Smaller city / suburban	\$85 – \$130/hr	\$255 – \$390	\$340 – \$520
Rural / low competition	\$70 – \$110/hr	\$210 – \$330	\$280 – \$440

3-Person Crew + Truck (Larger Moves)

Market Type	Rate Per Hour	Common Full-Day Total
Major metro	\$175 – \$260/hr	\$1,050 – \$2,080
Mid-size city	\$135 – \$200/hr	\$810 – \$1,600
Smaller city / suburban	\$115 – \$165/hr	\$690 – \$1,320

What Drives Rates Up or Down in Your Market

Labor costs. Your biggest variable. Paying movers \$18/hour is very different from \$24/hour. Your rate must reflect your actual labor cost or your margins collapse.

Fuel and truck costs. Route density matters. An operator servicing a tight urban area does more jobs per day with lower fuel costs than one driving 30 minutes between jobs.

Competition density. 20 moving companies in a city creates price pressure. 4 established companies in the same market allows healthier rates.

Reputation premium. An operator with 150+ Google reviews averaging 4.8 stars can charge 15 to 25% above market average. Reviews are the primary way customers decide on price sensitivity in this industry.

Long-Distance Moving Rates 2026

Interstate moves require FMCSA authority and are priced very differently from local moves.

Weight-based pricing (most common for interstate):

Move Distance	Rate Per 100 lbs	Typical 2BR Apartment (~5,000 lbs)
250 – 500 miles	\$0.40 – \$0.65/lb	\$2,000 – \$3,250
500 – 1,000 miles	\$0.55 – \$0.80/lb	\$2,750 – \$4,000
1,000 – 2,000 miles	\$0.65 – \$1.00/lb	\$3,250 – \$5,000
2,000+ miles	\$0.80 – \$1.20/lb	\$4,000 – \$6,000

Minimum charges: Most long-distance operators have a minimum of \$1,200 to \$1,800 regardless of weight.

Binding vs. non-binding estimates: Customers increasingly expect binding estimates (the price won't change after the move). Non-binding estimates create disputes. Structure your quotes accordingly.

Additional Services and Fees

This is where margin is protected or lost.

Packing Services

Service	Rate Range
Full packing service (per person, per hour)	\$45 – \$85/hr/packer
Partial packing (specific rooms)	Custom quote
Packing materials (boxes, tape, paper)	Cost + 30 to 50% markup

Packing is often your highest-margin add-on. Customers who need packing done professionally are less price-sensitive. Build it into your service offering explicitly.

Specialty Item Fees

Item	Typical Fee
Piano (upright)	\$150 – \$350 extra
Piano (grand)	\$350 – \$700 extra
Gun safe / large safes	\$150 – \$400 extra
Pool table (disassembly/reassembly)	\$250 – \$500 extra
Hot tub / large appliances	\$200 – \$450 extra
Artwork / antiques (white-glove)	Custom quote

Never move these items without a specialty fee. They require extra time, extra risk, and sometimes specialized equipment. If you don't charge for it, you'll absorb the cost and the liability.

Stair and Access Fees

Situation	Typical Fee
Stairs per flight (beyond 1st floor)	\$40 – \$100 per flight
Long carry (beyond 50 feet from truck)	\$50 – \$150
Elevator buildings	Often no extra charge
No parking / walk-up situation	\$50 – \$150

Communicate these clearly in your quote. Customers who are surprised by stair fees leave bad reviews. Customers who knew about them in advance and agreed are satisfied even when the bill is higher.

Storage

Many moves require short-term storage. Either you have the capability or you refer it out. If you have storage capacity:

Storage Type	Rate Range
Short-term storage (per month per room)	\$150 – \$350
Container storage	\$150 – \$300/month per container
Climate-controlled	20 to 40% premium

Storage converts one-time customers into monthly recurring revenue. Even 10 storage clients at \$200/month is \$2,000 in completely passive monthly income.

How to Calculate Your Hourly Floor

Before setting any rate, calculate what it costs you to run one truck for one hour:

Hourly operating cost breakdown:

Cost Item	Monthly	Per Working Hour (160 hrs/month)
Truck payment/lease	\$1,200 – \$2,000	\$7.50 – \$12.50
Commercial insurance	\$450 – \$900	\$2.81 – \$5.63
Fuel (\$3.80/gal, 8 MPG, 200 miles/day)	\$1,900	\$11.88
Maintenance reserve	\$400 – \$700	\$2.50 – \$4.38
2 Movers at \$20/hr	\$6,400	\$40.00
Supplies (blankets, dollies, etc.)	\$300 – \$600	\$1.88 – \$3.75
Overhead allocation (insurance, admin)	\$500 – \$1,000	\$3.13 – \$6.25
Total		\$69.70 – \$84.39/hr

Your floor rate is approximately \$70 to \$85 per hour for a 2-person crew.

At \$85/hour in a smaller market, you're breaking even. At \$115/hour, you're earning \$30/hour in gross margin. At \$130/hour, \$45/hour. Work backwards from a target margin to set your rate.

The Rate Card Trap to Avoid

Many moving companies set their hourly rate and leave everything else unstructured. Customers call with questions and get inconsistent quotes. Movers handle specialty items without charging for them. Storage is offered but not priced.

Build a complete rate card with:

- Base hourly rate by crew size
- Minimum hours and minimum charge
- Specialty item fees (listed explicitly)
- Stair and access fees
- Packing rates
- Travel fee structure (for jobs outside your core service area)
- Fuel surcharge policy (if applicable)

Publish the parts that build trust (base rates, minimums, specialty fees). The customer who calls knowing your rate structure is warmer, less likely to price-shop, and easier to close.

Want help setting rates that are competitive in your specific market? Book a free strategy call and we'll review what other operators are charging in your area.